The noble art of writing unimpressive stuff around impressive people

I think at its core this is an essay (what a big word! Let me retry) - I think at its core these are ramblings (better) about love. And while its first reader has indeed been my J. ❤️at home, I realised this when talking with S. while soapboxing on the first night - which I'll unfunnily keep calling the bar exam as it happened in a disused hotel bar. They said they had recognised me from a persistent heart shaped gesture (of the index and thumb kind) - and I admitted to indeed being continuously and deeply full of and dramatically in love with…well, almost everything.

Day 1, awoken by a wren and a chaffinch. Day 2, by a robin, a woodpecker and a wood pigeon.

The daffodils are in bloom, tiny metallic blue Altica beetles dot the purplish leaves of a willowherb curled within the bend of a muddy stream, and cars stream by the long road which cascades upwards in waterfall fashion into the misty horizon, pinched by the pulling compression of a towering electric pylon.

I'm not unwelcome in this sludge, soles firmly attached to the ground, and in reverse wet ground tightly clinging to my boots, the front of the right one ceding and opening a little after being slashed by the brambles. It's also a place that cannot meaningfully host me, I can only transiently be in it. Last night I talked about ecology with A., and throughout the little walk Bateson's *"Steps to an Ecology of Mind"* resonated in my head - not for its content, but for the title alone. Looking outside for connections and patterns to try and let the ones in my head emerge. And it sort-of worked.

I had arrived at the house with a somewhat clear idea of what to write: *"AI as an invasive species"*.

Invasion ecology researches what happens when organisms cross boundaries they were not *meant* (we can debate what that means) to cross, generally invited more or less willingly by humans, arriving somewhere they have no evolutionary relationship with, disrupting systems that organised themselves around their absence. AI infrastructure is sort of doing the same thing. Model deployments consume energy, water, and materials from ecosystems they have no relationship with and no accountability to. They are, in ecological terms, invasive.

But hey, think of sunlike dandelions: alien, yes, but generally kindly so. Less imperialistic (or vigorous as I've heard some people call the explosive I. glandulifera), and more capable of arriving where others would struggle in the beginning, drumming at the helm of a parade of exuberant pollinators. Feeble bridge, but the question which then appeared was of the type: "Can only the steward truly put roots everywhere, taking their kindness with themselves, and the joy to share the Universe with the else? Is kindness what ensures deserving a place in any form of heaven?". And then, I thought "time for a walk".

And time for a walk is time for connection - to the rhythm of what lies beyond this tall hedge, where on day 2 we saw someone emerge from. Weird. The daffodils, the beetles, the mud. Went by a shack outside - bright smiling people in a grey box, a large cup of powdered coffee costing less than half of what I would pay in London (and actually tasting better than most - no fancy sour tomato notes to pretend to like) - which later, in the house, I discovered being 100+ years old. Darkwood 1 from David Darling hums gravely in my headphones.

Then a piece shared by C. in the morning - with an endless list of contributors - came to mind. How to co-create and co-produce in a setting like this? We talk of playfulness with J., and I think I would like this to be a playful piece. Not deep, not pursuing an agenda, reminiscent of Buster Keaton in The General rolling out pieces of rail as the train goes.

By the end of the walk, the persistent thought is that maybe AI was indeed being an invasive species - in my brain. In a gorgeous house, in a new little town to explore and get to know, surrounded by extraordinary people and here I am, wanting to write about something that is not present, unless welcomed in the room by me. No, not a vampire, even though on Friday we discussed whether this old hotel is haunted (I'm solidly in the 'yes' camp) - and apparently the Caped Man of Hooks rides right outside the hedge. What if the goal of the retreat was not to move away from *everything* to focus on the screen, but to move towards this *something*, this collective shared buzzing energy to hold it and be present.

Then a puzzled cat appeared outside.

Oh, hi friend.

I share this document as I am still adding more words, and think about how weird it must be to be reading something while it's being written, to see a thought rotating in real time. The wood in the fireplace pops. A few moments (or likely minutes) later, J. stands up to go and grab some caramel digestive cookies - and upon returning spots something fluffy again - this time much, much closer and not separated from us by a glass pane and a few walls. It's *extremely* cute, and extremely docile. So much so that in possibly what will remain the strangest occurrence of the retreat I am able to gently scoop it up using a mug with a little piece of cookie in it (*If You Give a Mouse a Cookie…*), and equally gently deposit it outside, a little shivering - but seemingly unharmed, barring some disease (with I. we talk about *T. gondii*) - furball.

As someone said, a very Tom & Jerry situation.
One of my favourite things to read about, is the way animal sounds are rendered in different languages. This little rodent, kindly baptised *Clive* by H., which will assume polyglot and chatty, would say *squeak,* in English, *squit squit* in Italian, *zi zi* in Mandarin, *chuu chuu* in Japanese, but what I would have really loved to ask Clive is if Eliot's tiers in *The Naming of Cats* also applies to their brethren *(*The naming of *Rats* would have worked perfectly, but would have been rather inaccurate*).* Should we not receive an answer, we could attribute that to Clive resting their voice after damaging their vocal cords à la Gwen Verdon, ultimately leading to Liza Minnelli starring in Broadway's Chicago: by inhaling confetti. In my mind this scene is sort of playing like Clive eating an autograph, like a child famously did with Maurice Sendak's autograph, but I'm pretty sure Clive would be the one signing the autograph here. Eh, superstars… Let me close this by saying that a group of mice is called a **MISCHIEF**.

Sometimes I stop and think about the little creatures I take pictures of - which, since downloading iNaturalist are not an exiguous number. Barring some unprecedented disaster (which…yeah.), once they enter the decaying halls of the internet they are bound to some form of perpetual preservation. Would they care? As all living things are generally quite concerned with the conservation and continuation of the self, if made to understand would they see this artificial, fragile eternity as Heaven in their umwelt (we talked about Ed Yong yesterday)? Would they develop an animistic tradition of perceiving photographs as tools to steal one's soul and detest the process? Is capturing beetles pictures an imperialistic process at heart?

On the morning of day 2 the shower head finally remembered how to spout pleasantly hot water, which led to showering being an enjoyable activity, which led to me being 10 minutes late for the morning walk. Too much of a good thing. While returning we saw a fleet of motorcycles loudly vrooming. They looked cute, generally around retirement age, but they didn't let us cross the road. Bless them for finding a hobby, but how rude.

Endings are always the hardest part - it's the terrible peer pressure of decisions past, it's the awareness that joyful things are about to be no more, it's the difficulty to skillfully tie the loose ends. But one thing I'd like to close on is an amazing question asked by C. yesterday. During my bar exam, I started riffing on synthetic life, and (as asked by S.) why I'd much rather be in the room with a dozen exceptional people rather than 40 super intelligent agents. I don't think AI will ever become human, but I think it has the potential to become a sister species; something we cohabit to the world and are able to interact with (like dogs!), but that is fundamentally different from us, and will hold a mirror to all we are and care about. Whale we get there, let's hope to be the best parents we can be.